count, twenty-nine cricketers have represented two different countries at international level; fifteen have done so in Test cricket. Eoin Morgan, Boyd Rankin and Ed Joyce have all been on the conveyer belt between Irish and English cricket.

I never had to deal with the issue of circumstances curtailing my ability to fulfil my potential as a cricketer. I was lucky the opportunity to play cricket for England was my birthright. I have been brought up to support anyone who represents my nation. Without wishing to sound jingoistic, I'm English through and through.

I don't have the right to judge those who have done what they thought best for themselves. Morgan was a fantastic cricketer, denied his chance to play for Ireland beyond the odd one-day game – twenty-three, to be precise, between 2006 and 2009. He may not have lost his broad Irish accent and he may retain family roots in the land of his birth, but his life is in England. His heroes, principally Graham Thorpe, were English. The idea of playing for England began to take shape when he studied at Dulwich College in South London from the age of thirteen. He brought with him an intriguingly different set of skills. He played hurling as a schoolboy, growing up in Dublin. The grip for the two-sided bat, or hurley, is the same as the one used in cricket's reverse sweep.

The modern England team is, as we have discussed, a cultural and ethnic mix. Jonathan Trott, for instance, played Under-19 cricket for South Africa, but has had a British passport since birth, because his dad is English. He's had to take light-hearted stick as an adopted Brummie but feels very English. His children have been brought up here. He belongs.

Others will inevitably follow a similar path. Simon Harmer, a world-class off-break bowler who has had such an impact with us at Essex over the past couple of years that he now captains our T20 team, has extended his county contract until 2021. By then, although he played five Tests for South Africa in 2015, he will be eligible for England.

Kyle Abbott, who played eleven Tests, and Rilee Rossouw, who was being developed as understudy to AB de Villiers, caused controversy in South Africa in early 2017 by standing down from international cricket to sign long-term county deals with Hampshire. They argued that they were seeking greater financial security; I don't blame anyone for taking up opportunities as they occur in life.